

Word family: **dry** / **drier** / **driest** / **dryly** / **dryness** / **dry out** / **dried**

Base word: dry

Comparative: drier

Superlative: driest

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**, also **verb**

Related forms:

* **dry** (adj.) — 乾的；乾燥的；枯燥的；不甜的；冷淡的

* **dry** (v.) — 使乾；變乾

* **dried** (adj.) — 乾製的；曬乾的

* **dryly** (adv.) — 冷淡地；不動聲色地

* **dryness** (n.) — 乾燥；乾澀

* **dry out** — 變乾；脫水；戒酒

* **dry up** — 乾涸；枯竭；突然說不出話

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **dry subject**

* **dry book / lecture**

* **dry weather**

* **dry skin**

* **dry clothes**

* **dry land**

* **dry wine**

* **dry humour**

* **dry voice / reply**

* **dry spell**

* **dry season**

* **keep dry**

* **dry something**

* **dry out**

* **dry up**

Meaning in this passage

> He taught history, but he never treated it as a **dry subject** full of names and dates.

Here, **dry** means:

dull, factual, and lacking in interest or emotional engagement — 枯燥的；乏味的

The speaker means that Mr Chan did not teach history as if it were only boring facts to memorize.

****中文翻譯：****

他從不把歷史當成一門只有人名和年份的****枯燥科目****。

So here:

****dry subject = 枯燥、乏味、缺乏生氣的科目****

1. ****dry subject / topic — 枯燥的科目 / 話題****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He never treated history as a ****dry subject****.

他從不把歷史當成一門****枯燥的科目****。

Practice 2

> Economics can seem ****dry**** if it is taught only through definitions.

如果只靠定義來教，經濟學可能會顯得很****枯燥****。

Practice 3

> The topic sounds ****dry****, but the speaker made it interesting.

這個題目聽起來很****沉悶****，但講者把它講得很有趣。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry = 缺乏趣味、感情或生動表達，令人覺得沉悶的****

2. ****dry book / lecture / writing — 枯燥的書 / 講座 / 文章****

Practice 1

> The textbook is informative but rather ****dry****.

這本課本資料豐富，但頗為****枯燥****。

Practice 2

> His lecture was too **dry** and technical.

他的講座太**枯燥而技術化**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry book/lecture/writing = 資訊很多，但缺乏生動性或趣味的內容

3. **dry** (沒有水分的) — 乾的

A core literal sense.

Practice 1

> The towel is completely **dry**.

毛巾完全**乾了**。

Practice 2

> Keep the floor **dry**.

保持地面**乾爽**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry = 沒有水、濕氣或水分的

4. **dry clothes / hair** — 乾的衣服 / 頭髮

Practice 1

> Put on some **dry clothes**.

穿上**乾衣服**吧。

Practice 2

> Her hair was still **dry** despite the rain.

儘管下雨，她的頭髮仍然是**乾的**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry = 沒有被水弄濕的****

5. ****dry weather / climate — 乾燥的天氣 / 氣候****

Practice 1

> The region has a hot, ****dry climate****.

這個地區氣候炎熱而****乾燥****。

Practice 2

> We had several weeks of ****dry weather****.

我們有幾個星期都是****乾燥少雨的天氣****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry weather/climate = 雨量少、空氣濕度低的天氣或氣候****

6. ****dry season — 旱季****

Practice 1

> Roads are easier to use during the ****dry season****.

在****旱季****，道路較容易通行。

Practice 2

> The river becomes much smaller in the ****dry season****.

河流在****旱季****會縮小很多。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry season = 一年中降雨量明顯較少的一段時期****

7. ****dry skin / lips — 乾燥皮膚 / 嘴唇****

Practice 1

> Cold weather can cause ****dry skin****.

寒冷天氣會令皮膚****乾燥****。

Practice 2

> Use lip balm if your lips are ****dry****.

如果嘴唇****乾燥****，可以使用潤唇膏。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry skin/lips = 缺乏天然水分或油分而變得乾燥的皮膚 / 嘴唇****

8. ****dry throat / mouth — 口乾；喉嚨乾****

Practice 1

> My throat feels ****dry****.

我的喉嚨很****乾****。

Practice 2

> He woke up with a ****dry mouth****.

他醒來時覺得****口乾****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry throat/mouth = 因水分不足而感到乾澀****

9. ****dry land — 陸地；乾地****

Practice 1

> After hours at sea, we finally reached ****dry land****.

在海上幾個小時後，我們終於到達****陸地****。

Practice 2

> The animals moved to ****dry ground****.

動物移到**乾燥的地面**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry land = 不被水覆蓋的陸地

10. **dry food — 乾糧；乾的食物**

Practice 1

> We packed **dry food** for the trip.

我們為旅程準備了**乾糧**。

Practice 2

> The cat prefers **dry food**.

那隻貓較喜歡**乾糧**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry food = 含水量低、不是液體或濕食的食物

11. **dried fruit / dried food — 乾果 / 乾製食物**

Practice 1

> She added **dried fruit** to the cereal.

她在穀物早餐中加入了**乾果**。

Practice 2

> **Dried fish** can be stored for a long time.

魚乾可以保存很久。

MCQ-ready definition:

dried = 經過曬乾、風乾或其他處理去除水分的

12. **dry wine — 不甜的酒；乾型酒**

A distinct food-and-drink sense.

Practice 1

> He prefers **dry white wine**.

他比較喜歡**乾白酒 / 不甜的白酒**。

Practice 2

> This wine is quite **dry**.

這款酒相當**不甜**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry wine = 糖分低、味道不甜的酒

13. **dry humour / wit — 冷面幽默；不動聲色的幽默**

A major figurative sense.

Practice 1

> He has a very **dry sense of humour**.

他有很強的**冷面幽默感**。

Practice 2

> Her **dry wit** made everyone laugh.

她那種**不動聲色的幽默**令大家發笑。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry humour = 用平靜、嚴肅、近乎沒有表情的方式說出幽默內容

14. **dryly — 冷淡 / 不動聲色地**

Practice 1

> “Very clever,” she said ****dryly****.

「真聰明啊。」她****冷冷地 / 不動聲色地****說。

Practice 2

> He replied ****dryly**** that the plan had “worked perfectly.”

他****冷淡而帶諷刺地****回答說，這個計劃「運作得非常完美」。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dryly = 以平淡、冷靜、常帶諷刺意味的方式說話****

15. ****dry voice / reply — 冷淡、平板的聲音 / 回答****

Practice 1

> She gave a ****dry reply****.

她給了一個****冷淡簡短的回答****。

Practice 2

> His ****dry tone**** suggested that he was not impressed.

他那種****平淡冷冷的語氣****顯示他並不欣賞。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry voice/reply = 缺乏感情、熱情或明顯情緒的語氣 / 回答****

16. ****dry facts / statistics — 枯燥的事實 / 數據****

Practice 1

> The teacher turned ****dry facts**** into memorable stories.

老師把****枯燥的事實****變成令人難忘的故事。

Practice 2

> A list of ****dry statistics**** can be hard to remember.

一串**枯燥數據**可能很難記住。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry facts/statistics = 只有資料和數字、缺乏生動背景或情感的內容****

17. ****dry spell (天氣：一段無雨期) — 乾旱期；少雨期****

Practice 1

> The region is experiencing a long ****dry spell****.

這個地區正在經歷一段很長的****少雨期****。

Practice 2

> The garden suffered during the ****dry spell****.

花園在那段****乾旱期****受了影響。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry spell = 一段持續沒有下雨或很少下雨的時間****

18. ****dry spell (figurative：低潮期) — 一段沒有成果的時期****

Practice 1

> The striker ended a long scoring ****dry spell****.

那名前鋒終結了長時間的****入球荒****。

Practice 2

> The writer went through a creative ****dry spell****.

那名作家經歷了一段****創作低潮期****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry spell = 比喻某方面長時間沒有成果、成功或進展的時期****

19. ****dry (verb：使乾) — 弄乾；使乾燥****

Practice 1

> **Dry your hands** before touching the equipment.

接觸設備前先把手**擦乾**。

Practice 2

> She **dried her hair** with a towel.

她用毛巾把頭髮**弄乾**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry something = 去除某物的水分，令其變乾****

20. ****dry (intransitive : 變乾) — 乾掉；變乾****

Practice 1

> Leave the paint to **dry**.

讓油漆**乾掉**。

Practice 2

> The clothes **dried** quickly in the sun.

衣服在陽光下很快便**乾了**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry = 水分逐漸消失而變乾****

21. ****dry out — 變得過分乾燥；乾透****

Practice 1

> The soil **dried out** during the hot weather.

泥土在炎熱天氣下**乾透了**。

Practice 2

> Don't let the cake ****dry out****.

不要讓蛋糕****變得太乾****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry out = 失去大量水分而變得非常乾燥****

22. ****dry out (person : 戒酒 / 停止飲酒) — 戒酒****

A lexicalized informal use.

Practice 1

> He entered a clinic to ****dry out****.

他進入診所接受治療以****戒酒****。

Practice 2

> He needed time to ****dry out**** after years of heavy drinking.

多年大量飲酒後，他需要一段時間****戒酒康復****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry out = informal: 停止大量飲酒並讓身體恢復****

23. ****dry up (液體 / 河流 : 乾涸) — 乾涸****

Practice 1

> The river ****dried up**** during the drought.

河流在旱災期間****乾涸了****。

Practice 2

> The well has ****dried up****.

那口井已經****乾涸****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry up = 液體來源完全或幾乎完全消失****

24. ****dry up (資源 / 供應：枯竭) — 枯竭；停止****

Practice 1

> Funding suddenly ****dried up****.

資金突然****枯竭了****。

Practice 2

> Orders began to ****dry up****.

訂單開始****逐漸消失****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry up = 比喻供應、資金、機會等逐漸減少直至幾乎沒有****

25. ****dry up (說話：突然說不出話) — 突然語塞****

Practice 1

> I completely ****dried up**** during the interview.

我在面試時突然****腦袋一片空白、說不出話來****。

Practice 2

> Halfway through the speech, he ****dried up****.

演講到一半時，他突然****語塞了****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****dry up = informal: 說話時突然想不到內容，無法繼續****

26. ****dry run — 預演；試運行****

A common fixed expression.

Practice 1

> Let's do a **dry run** before the presentation.

正式匯報前我們先做一次**預演**。

Practice 2

> The team carried out a **dry run** of the new procedure.

團隊為新程序進行了一次**試運行**。

MCQ-ready definition:

dry run = 在正式進行之前所做的完整測試或預演

Important distinction 1: **dry** vs **boring**

In your passage these are close, but:

boring

directly means not interesting.

dry

often means boring **because it is overly factual, technical, unemotional, or academic**.

So:

> a dry history lesson

suggests facts and dates without lively storytelling.

That nuance fits your passage perfectly.

Important distinction 2: **dry** vs **dull**

dull

broadly lacking excitement or interest.

dry

often specifically lacking vividness, emotion, humour, or engaging presentation.

A lecture can be both dry and dull.

Important distinction 3: ****dry vs serious****

A ****dry**** subject is not necessarily serious.

A comedy lecture can be dry if presented in an overly factual way.

So:

****dry ≠ serious****

Important distinction 4: ****dry vs plain****

****plain food****

simple, lightly seasoned.

****dry food****

low in moisture.

> plain rice

白飯 / 沒有配料的飯

> dry rice

乾硬、缺乏水分的飯

Very different.

Important distinction 5: ****dry vs dehydrated****

****dry****

general lack of moisture.

dehydrated

usually means excessive loss of water, especially from a body or food product.

> dry skin

乾燥皮膚

> dehydrated person

脫水的人

Important distinction 6: **dry vs arid**

dry

ordinary broad word.

arid

more formal and especially used for climates/land with extremely little rain.

> dry climate

乾燥氣候

> arid desert region

乾旱沙漠地區

Important distinction 7: **dry wine vs plain wine**

dry wine

not sweet.

plain wine

not a standard way to describe sweetness.

This is a lexicalized food-and-drink sense.

Important distinction 8: ****dry humour vs sarcastic humour****

****dry humour****

delivered without much expression, often as if serious.

****sarcastic humour****

uses irony to mock or criticize.

Dry humour can be sarcastic, but not necessarily.

Important distinction 9: ****dryly vs coldly****

****dryly****

flat, understated, often humorous or ironic.

****coldly****

without warmth or friendliness.

A dry reply may be witty; a cold reply may simply be unfriendly.

Important distinction 10: ****dry spell literal vs figurative****

Literal

> a dry spell

一段少雨期

Figurative

> a scoring dry spell

一段入球荒

The figurative use extends the idea of ****a period where something normally flowing or occurring**

has stopped**.

Important distinction 11: **dry out vs dry**

dry

become not wet.

dry out

often means become **completely or excessively** dry.

> The clothes dried.

衣服乾了。

> The soil dried out.

泥土乾透了。

Important distinction 12: **dry up vs dry out**

dry out

lose moisture.

dry up

often means a liquid source disappears completely, or figuratively a supply stops.

> The soil dried out.

泥土變乾。

> The river dried up.

河流乾涸。

Important distinction 13: **dried vs dry**

dry

describes current state.

> dry clothes

乾衣服

dried

often means something was deliberately processed by removing moisture.

> dried fruit

乾果

So **dried fruit** is not merely fruit that happens to be dry.

Family-extension note

Dry is a very strong polysemy family because it spreads from a literal physical core into several well-established abstract meanings.

The central literal idea is:

lacking water or moisture

From that, English develops:

1. **physical condition**

- * dry clothes
- * dry skin
- * dry climate

2. **food/drink**

- * dry food
- * dried fruit
- * dry wine

3. **intellectual/emotional lack**

- * dry subject

- * dry lecture
- * dry facts

4. **delivery/style**

- * dry humour
- * dry reply
- * dryly

5. **period without supply/activity**

- * dry spell
- * scoring dry spell

6. **verbs**

- * dry clothes
- * dry out
- * dry up

7. **fixed expression**

- * dry run

For your passage, the crucial metaphor is:

lack of moisture → lack of liveliness

So **dry history** means history presented without enough human interest, emotion, narrative, or energy.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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dry subject	枯燥的科目	lacking interest	
dry lecture/book	枯燥講座 / 書	overly factual	
dry facts	枯燥事實	unemotional data	
dry (not wet)	乾的	no moisture	
dry clothes	乾衣服	not wet	
dry weather	乾燥天氣	little rain/moisture	
dry season	旱季	low-rain period	
dry skin	乾燥皮膚	low moisture	
dry mouth	口乾	lack of moisture	

dry land	陸地	not water-covered	
dry food	乾糧	low moisture	
dried fruit	乾果	processed by drying	
dry wine	乾型 / 不甜的酒	low sugar	
dry humour	冷面幽默	understated humour	
dry reply	冷淡 / 平淡回答	low emotional warmth	
dryly	不動聲色地	flat/ironic delivery	
dry spell	少雨期	period without rain	
dry spell (fig.)	低潮期 / 荒	period without success	
dry something	弄乾	remove moisture	
dry out	乾透	lose much moisture	
dry out (person)	戒酒	informal rehabilitation	
dry up	乾涸	source disappears	
dry up (fig.)	枯竭	supply disappears	
dry up (speech)	語塞	suddenly cannot continue	
dry run	預演 ; 試運行	practice test	

For your original sentence

> He taught history, but he never treated it as a **dry subject** full of names and dates.

Here:

dry = 枯燥、乏味、只重資料而缺乏生動感的

The phrase **full of names and dates** explains exactly what kind of dryness the speaker means: history taught as memorization rather than as meaningful human stories.

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他從不把歷史當成一門只有人名和年份的**枯燥科目**。

For this passage, **「枯燥」** is the cleanest and most precise translation.